

Three-dimensional MHD evolution of an ultramassive white dwarf

with differential rotation and a mixed field

Initial and final states at 192^3 and 256^3 — interim report

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Abstract

A $2.005 M_\odot$ equilibrium with strong differential rotation and a toroidal-dominated field, evolved in three-dimensional ideal MHD at two resolutions. **The star survives and keeps its mass; its ordered field does not.** At 192^3 , run to $t = 60$ s, the magnetic energy falls by a factor of 2170 and the toroidal-to-poloidal amplitude ratio from 338 to 1.07, while the mass stays within 0.3% and the differential rotation is not erased. The instability is non-axisymmetric, $m = 1$, and grows in a few Alfvén times. Its rate is not converged — it rises 47% from 192^3 to 256^3 — and the post-saturation decay is not converged either, in the opposite direction. The 256^3 run reaches $t = 8.5$ s so far.

1 Initial state

1.1 The star

Mass	M	$2.0052 M_\odot$
	$M/M_{\text{Ch}} (\mu_e = 2)$	1.38
Central density	ρ_c	$3.00 \times 10^9 \text{ g cm}^{-3}$
Mean density	$\langle \rho \rangle$	$3.30 \times 10^7 \text{ g cm}^{-3}$
Equatorial radius	R_{eq}	$3.917 \times 10^8 \text{ cm}$
Polar radius	R_{pol}	$1.501 \times 10^8 \text{ cm}$
Oblateness	$R_{\text{pol}}/R_{\text{eq}}$	0.383
Volume-equivalent radius	R_{vol}	$3.07 \times 10^8 \text{ cm}$
Rotation law	$\Omega(\varpi) = \Omega_c A^2 / (A^2 + \varpi^2)$	$A = 1.834 \times 10^8 \text{ cm}$
Central angular velocity	Ω_c	8.193 rad s^{-1} ($P = 0.77 \text{ s}$)
Equatorial angular velocity	$\Omega(R_{\text{eq}})$	1.47 rad s^{-1} ($P = 4.3 \text{ s}$)
Degree of differential rotation	$\Omega_c / \Omega(R_{\text{eq}})$	5.6
Equatorial velocity	v_{eq}	$6.2 \times 10^3 \text{ km s}^{-1} = 0.021 c$
Rotational support	$T/ W $	0.0993
Mass shedding	$\Omega_{\text{eq}}^2 R_{\text{eq}} / g_{\text{eq}}$	0.469
Dynamical time	t_{dyn}	0.475 s
Alfvén time	t_A	2.383 s
Central rotation period	P_{rot}	0.767 s

Table 1: The configuration. It lies 38% above the Chandrasekhar mass and can only exist because of the differential rotation, which is also why it is so flattened. It is not at breakup (47% of shedding) and is below both bar-mode thresholds ($T/|W| = 0.099$ against 0.14 secular and 0.27 dynamical). The surface period of 4.3 s is some three times shorter than the fastest white dwarf spin claimed in the literature; this is a merger-remnant-like configuration, not a model of an observed star.

1.2 The fields

	analytic model	192 ³ grid	256 ³ grid
$\max B_\varphi $ (G)	3.231×10^{13}	3.196×10^{13}	3.204×10^{13}
$\max B_{\text{pol}} $ (G)	7.63×10^9	9.46×10^{10}	8.41×10^{10}
$\max B /B_c$	0.732	0.724	0.726
E_{mag} (erg)	6.035×10^{49}	6.035×10^{49}	6.056×10^{49}
$E_{\text{tor}}/E_{\text{mag}}$	0.99999995	0.999997	0.999998
$E_{\text{tor}}/E_{\text{pol}}$	2.18×10^7	3.11×10^5	5.22×10^5
$\max B_\varphi /\max B_{\text{pol}} $	4234	338	381
$E_{\text{pol}}/ W $	5.2×10^{-10}	—	—
Toroidal filling factor	—	1.23%	—

Table 2: Mixed field, toroidal-dominated to one part in 10^7 by energy: a 10^9 G exterior dipole beside a 3×10^{13} G interior toroidal field. The peak toroidal field is reconstructed on the grid to 98.9% of the model value at 192³; the poloidal component is not, because interpolating an axisymmetric model onto a Cartesian mesh injects poloidal field an order of magnitude above the true one. *The poloidal quantities at $t = 0$ are therefore numerical floors, not physics*, and the growth measured later is counted against them. The filling factor is $8\pi E_{\text{tor}}/\max |B_\varphi|^2$ over the stellar volume.

1.3 Equation of state and method

Equation of state	ztwd : zero-temperature degenerate electrons, $\mu_e = 2$ barotropic , $P = P(\rho)$; all $\partial/\partial T$ vanish, $c_V = c_P = 0$
Code	CASTRO 26.07 / AMReX; ideal MHD, constrained transport, HLLD
Grid	3D Cartesian, single level, box 1.8×10^9 cm per side 192 ³ : $dx = 9.375 \times 10^6$ cm 256 ³ : 7.031×10^6 cm
Gravity	PoissonGrav , full 3D solve (the quadrupole is large at $R_{\text{pol}}/R_{\text{eq}} = 0.38$)
Initial condition	Grad-Shafranov/SCF on 385×769 (ϖ, z), interpolated from A
CFL	0.5 at 192 ³ ; 0.3 at 256 ³ past $t \simeq 4.8$ s
Floor / sponge	$\rho_{\text{min}} = 10^2$ against ambient 2×10^4 ; sponge 10^4 – 10^5
Diagnostics	rebuilt from B_x, B_y, B_z ; the native emag_density , etor_density and Div_B derives are corrupt (see Sec. 5)

2 Final states

2.1 Same instant, both grids

2.2 The end state, 192³

Only the 192³ run has reached a steady late state; it was carried to $t = 60$ s and stopped changing well before that.

Three points in Table 4 carry most of the physics.

The mass does not move. 0.02% from start to end, 0.3% in amplitude along the way, while the magnetic energy of the same star falls by a factor of 2170. Whatever destroys the field does not unbind the star.

The differential rotation survives. $\Omega_{\text{core}}/\Omega_{\text{mean}}$ is 1.72 over the first snapshots and 1.70 over the last: the shape of the rotation profile is the same at $t = 60$ s as at the start. The magnetic

$t \simeq 5.2 \text{ s}$	192 ³	256 ³	ratio
E_{tor} (erg)	1.965×10^{49}	1.784×10^{49}	0.91
E_{pol} (erg)	1.791×10^{48}	2.510×10^{48}	1.40
$E_{\text{mag}}/E_{\text{mag}}(0)$	35.5%	33.6%	
$E_{\text{tor}}/E_{\text{pol}}$	11.0	7.1	
$\max B_{\varphi} $ (G)	4.539×10^{13}	4.045×10^{13}	0.89
$\max B_{\text{pol}} $ (G)	3.827×10^{13}	3.104×10^{13}	0.81
$\max B_{\varphi} /\max B_{\text{pol}} $	1.19	1.30	
$\max B /B_c$	1.118	0.931	
M ($M_{\odot}$)	2.0035	2.0031	
R_{vol} (10^8 cm)	3.51	2.97	

Table 3: The two grids at the same physical time, at the end of the growth phase. They agree on the state to within tens of percent, but not on the rate that got there — see Sec. 4.

192 ³	$t = 0$	$t = 38.5 \text{ s}$	change
<i>The star</i>			
M ($M_{\odot}$)	2.00667	2.00618	−0.02%
R_{vol} (10^8 cm)	3.068	2.716	−11%
R_{eq} (10^8 cm)	3.750	3.204	−15%
$R_{\text{pol}}/R_{\text{eq}}$	0.425	0.556	rounder
$\Omega_{\text{core}}/\Omega_{\text{mean}}$	1.72	1.70	unchanged
<i>The field</i>			
E_{mag} (erg)	6.035×10^{49}	2.782×10^{46}	/ 2170
E_{tor} (erg)	6.035×10^{49}	2.658×10^{46}	/ 2270
E_{pol} (erg)	1.942×10^{44}	1.236×10^{45}	×6.4
$E_{\text{tor}}/E_{\text{pol}}$	3.11×10^5	21.5	/ 1.4×10^4
$\max B_{\varphi} $ (G)	3.196×10^{13}	1.227×10^{12}	/ 26
$\max B_{\text{pol}} $ (G)	9.46×10^{10}	1.148×10^{12}	×12
$\max B_{\varphi} /\max B_{\text{pol}} $	338	1.07	/ 316
$\max B /B_c$	0.724	0.031	

Table 4: Initial and end state at 192³. The star keeps its mass to 0.02% and its differential rotation; the field is reduced by three orders of magnitude in energy and ends with its two components equal in peak strength.

transport was real — L_z falls at $0.206\% \text{ s}^{-1}$ while the toroidal field lives and $0.099\% \text{ s}^{-1}$ after it is gone, a factor of 2.1 — but it never had the time or the strength to erase the rotation that holds $2 M_{\odot}$ above the Chandrasekhar mass. *The star survives because it never lost what supports it.*

“Destroyed” means disordered, not weakened — until late. At $t = 5.2 \text{ s}$ the peak toroidal field is *higher* than initially, 4.54×10^{13} against $3.20 \times 10^{13} \text{ G}$, while the energy has fallen by a factor of three: the field is concentrating into filaments, its effective volume dropping from 1.49×10^{24} to $2.40 \times 10^{23} \text{ cm}^3$. Only afterwards does the peak collapse as well, to $1.23 \times 10^{12} \text{ G}$.

3 The evolution between them

The field goes through three phases, all visible in Fig. 1.

The mode is $m = 1$. An azimuthal Fourier projection gives $|m=1|/|m=0| = 1.2 \times 10^{-16}$ at $t = 0$ — the initial condition is axisymmetric to machine precision. From $t \simeq 2.5 \text{ s}$ the poloidal field is $m = 1$ dominated, with $|B_{z,m=1}|/|B_{z,m=0}|$ reaching 21 at $t = 4 \text{ s}$, and the toroidal $m = 1$ saturates

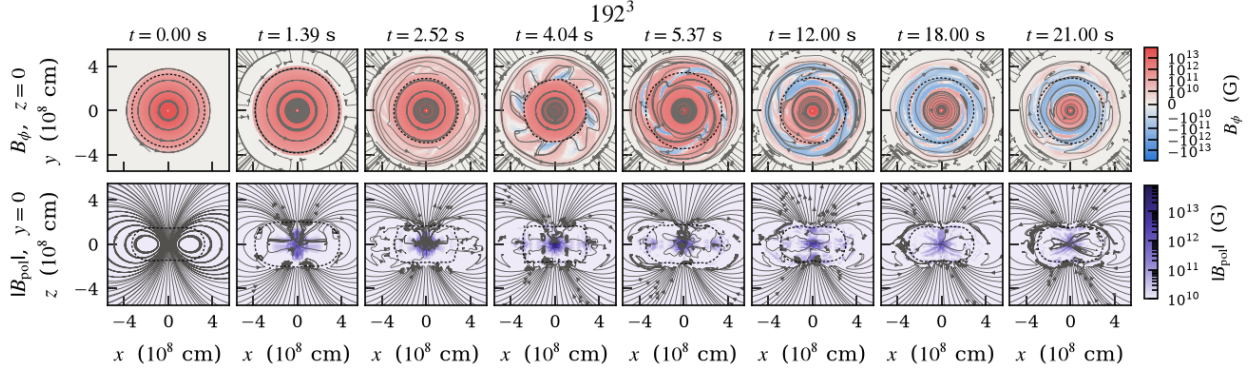


Figure 1: 192^3 . **Top:** equatorial cut $z = 0$, where B_ϕ lies in the plane, so the streamlines *are* the toroidal field lines — circles while the star is axisymmetric. **Bottom:** meridional cut $y = 0$, where the in-plane field *is* the poloidal one. Colour is B_ϕ and $|B_{\text{pol}}|$ respectively, both starting at 10^{10} G so the two rows are comparable; the near-empty poloidal panel at $t = 0$ is the statement that the poloidal field is three decades below the toroidal one. Same scales as Fig. 4.

Phase	Window	Rate	Signature
Growth	$t = 1.3\text{--}4.0$ s	$\sigma = 1.369 \text{ s}^{-1}$ ($r = 0.994$) e -fold of amplitude $0.61 t_A$	E_{pol} exponential; $m = 1$ takes over
Saturation	$t \simeq 5.3$ s	—	E_{pol} peaks at $10^4 \times$ its floor; $\max B_\phi / \max B_{\text{pol}} \rightarrow 1.19$
Decay	$t = 5.4\text{--}30$ s	e -fold $3.6\text{--}4.0$ s	E_{tor} falls 10^3
Residual	$t > 30$ s	e -fold 37 s	$E_{\text{mag}} \simeq 3 \times 10^{46}$ erg, flat

Table 5: Phases of the field evolution at 192^3 . The decay stalls after $t \simeq 30$ s: the field does not go to zero but settles at a disordered residual of order 10^{12} G.

at $\simeq 10\%$ of the axisymmetric component. This rules out the axisymmetric MRI, which could not exist here in any case: built from the *vertical* field, $\lambda_{\text{MRI}} = 2.9 \times 10^4$ cm, or 0.003 of a cell. What remains is the Tayler kink or the non-axisymmetric toroidal-field MRI, which the mode number alone cannot separate.

The star pulsates and does not stop. Past the initial transient, ρ_{max} settles into a clean periodic oscillation of period 1.498 s ($3.15 t_{\text{dyn}}$, 1.95 rotations) at $\pm 14.4\%$, with an envelope e -folding near 140 s. It is still running at $t = 60$ s.

4 Numerical convergence

Settling the rate would need 384^3 , about five times the cost of 256^3 . The alternative, and probably the right one, is explicit resistivity, giving the problem a physical dissipation scale instead of letting the mesh set it; CASTRO does not currently implement it.

5 Caveats

1. **The EOS is barotropic.** *ztwd* has no thermal reservoir, so the 6×10^{49} erg that leave the field have no physical destination and are dissipated at the grid scale. We can say the ordered field is destroyed; we cannot say where the energy went. The stratification is also neutral, with no buoyancy to limit the mode — in a stratified star the rate would be lower, making σ a *physical* upper bound while it is a *numerical* lower bound.

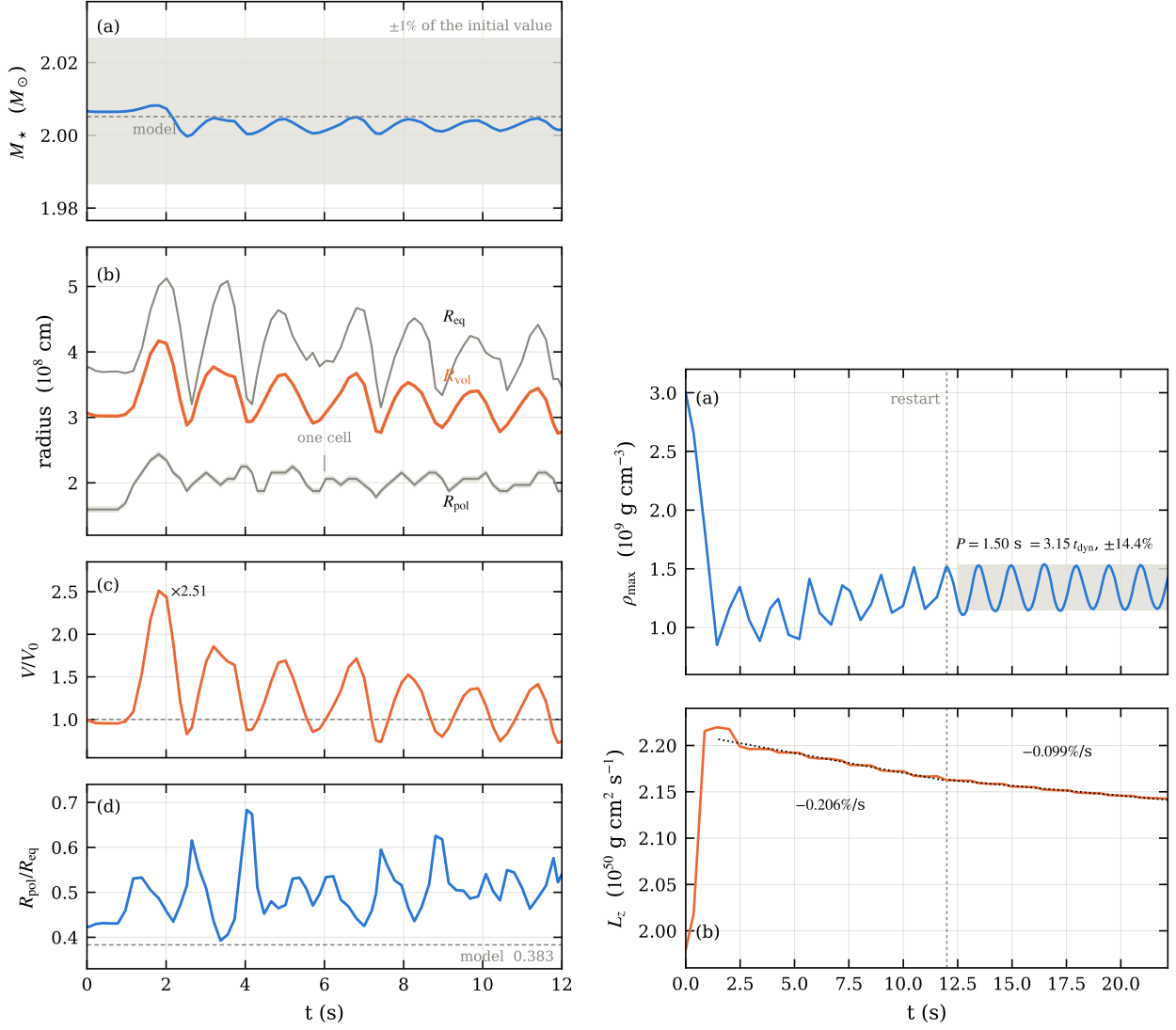


Figure 2: Left, 192³ to $t = 12$ s: mass against a $\pm 1\%$ band; the three radii with one grid cell drawn around R_{pol} ; volume; oblateness. Right, to $t = 22$ s: central density, and axial angular momentum with the two braking rates fitted. The dashed vertical is the restart at $t = 12$ s.

2. **Part of the run is outside the EOS validity range.** $\max |B|$ reaches $1.41 B_c$ at $t = 4.0$ s and exceeds the Landau critical field in 44% of the sampled instants between $t \simeq 2$ and 9 s. The late state, at $0.03 B_c$, is well inside.
3. **The poloidal field at $t = 0$ is a numerical floor.** Cartesian interpolation of an axisymmetric model injects E_{pol} some 70 times above the model's value even at 256³. All poloidal growth is measured against that floor, which is why it is quoted alongside.
4. **256³ has not reached a final state.** It stands at $t = 8.5$ s of a 12 s target, so every statement about the late evolution rests on one resolution.
5. **Native magnetic diagnostics are unusable.** `emag_density`, `etor_density` and `Div_B` pack face-centred components of different index types into one cell-centred FAB and read past the end of the box, `Div_B` reaching 3×10^{146} where it should be ~ 0 . Everything here is rebuilt from B_x, B_y, B_z , which are correct.

	192 ³	256 ³	verdict
Mass range ($M_{\odot}$)	1.9997–2.0082	2.0021–2.0073	converged
$R_{\text{vol}}(t=0)$ (10^8 cm)	3.068	3.069	converged (0.03%)
σ from E_{pol} (s^{-1})	1.369	2.007	+47%, not converged
σ from the $m=1$ mode (s^{-1})	1.968	2.752	+40%, same factor
$E_{\text{pol}}(t=0)$, the floor (erg)	1.94×10^{44}	1.16×10^{44}	finer seed is smaller
$\min(\max B_{\varphi} / \max B_{\text{pol}})$	1.19	0.805	instability goes further
Decay e -fold, $t = 6.5$ – 8.5 s	3.8 s	7.3 s	$\times 1.9$, not converged
First volume peak	$2.51 V_0$	$1.79 V_0$	early pulsation is numerical

Table 6: Three verdicts. Mass and volume are converged. The growth rate rises with resolution and the decay rate falls, both by about a factor of two per refinement, so the measured growth is a lower bound and the measured decay an upper bound: the coarse grid exaggerates the violence at both ends. The early large-amplitude pulsation is largely the initial condition ringing on the mesh.

Status

192³: complete, $t = 60$ s. 256³: running, $t = 8.5$ s of 12 s.

Inputs, submission scripts, diagnostic tools, data and figure code are under version control in the WD_MAG repository.

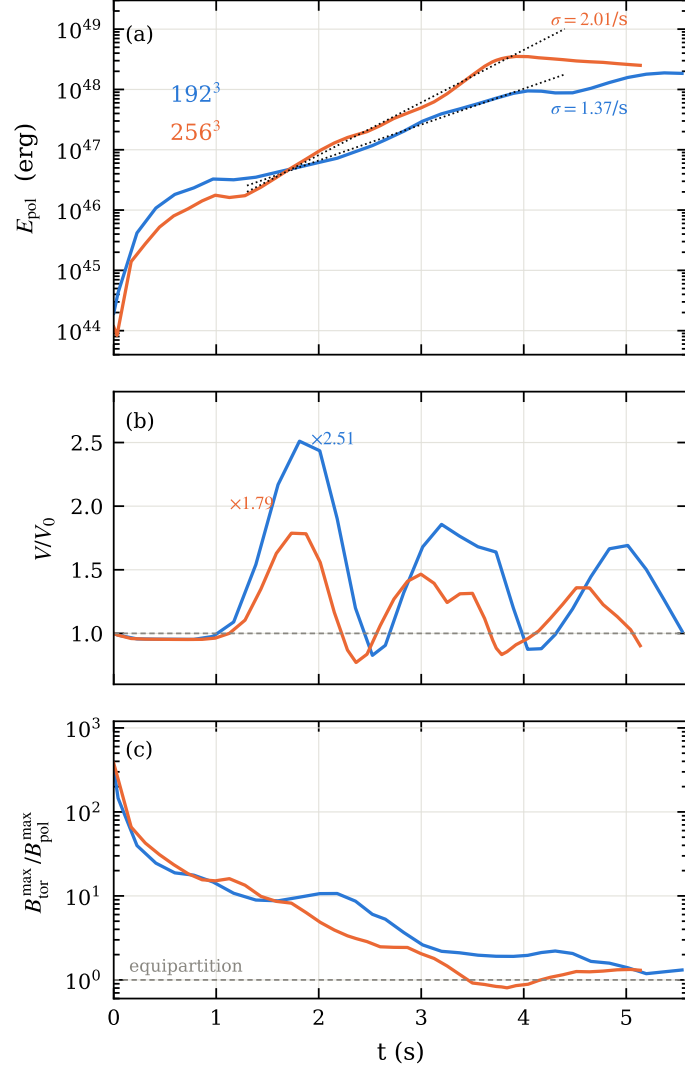


Figure 3: 192^3 against 256^3 over the growth phase: poloidal energy with the fits, volume, and the amplitude ratio with equipartition marked.

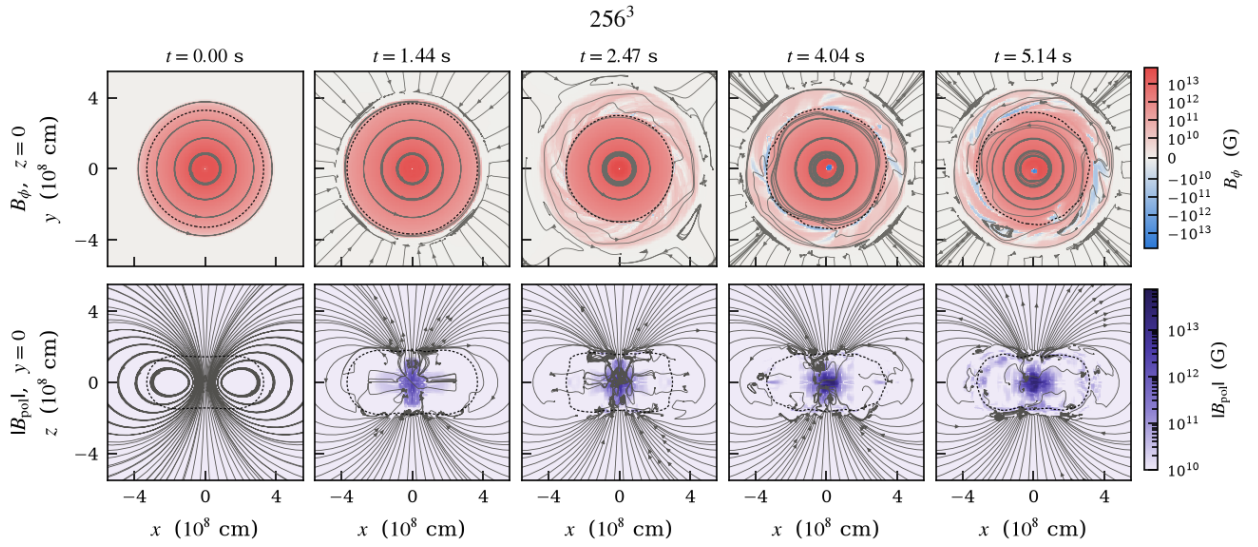


Figure 4: 256^3 , same layout, planes and colour scales as Fig. 1.